

Woody Guthrie

His words and music fed a generation of free-thinkers and with Bob Dylan among his biggest fans his 'legend' status stands unassailable.



Woody Guthrie:
his 'machine
kills fascists!'

Woody was prolific. He not only sang and wrote his own songs but he drew, wrote poetry and novels and was also a prominent activist. He enlisted in the army during World War II and wrote many anti-Hitler songs and pro-war pieces, all of which served to rally the troops.

Returning from the war his health waned and he was diagnosed with Huntington's disease. However, while he was in hospital a whole new generation (including Bob Dylan and Joan Baez, leaders of the next wave of protest singers) were taking an interest in his

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music. In this way Woody was able to pass the torch onto the next generation.

Guthrie's playing always served as an accompaniment to his voice, but was never sidelined; indeed it's lively and infectious and, as with many great blues artists, features an interesting level of complexity as basslines weave against strummed chords to create a sound that is full and rich at all times.

Woody had the warning: 'This machine kills fascists!' emblazoned onto his Gibson, defining him as the ultimate protest singer! **SR**

Info Will improve your...

KEY G major
TEMPO 120 bpm

- ✓ Solo accompaniment
- ✓ Alternating bass lines
- ✓ Dynamics

Looking at the forefathers of acoustic folk guitar styles – where better to begin than with the grandfather of the genre: Woody Guthrie. Living through some of the most tempestuous episodes of the 20th century: the Great Depression, World War II, the rise of communism and the Cold War – certainly shaped Guthrie into the artist he became.

He was born in Okemah, Oklahoma in July 1912 and grew up in a family where singing was a well-practised tradition, from Scottish folk to American traditional songs. His first stab at a musical career came in the early

1930s when he moved to Texas, but the onset of the Great Depression meant that he was soon on the road and looking for work, guitar in hand, and it was singing and playing that helped to pay his way.

In 1937 he arrived in California and started to perform on a local radio station singing traditional songs along with some of his own. Things started to pick up pace from here as the radio show also gave him a platform to air his political views and shaped him as the social commentator we think of today. Ever the restless wanderer, Woody moved to New York in 1940 and befriended those artists we now think of as forming the great folk canon: Pete Seeger, Leadbelly, Sonny Terry, Josh White and many more. Together they made music but, just as importantly, they campaigned for the common man and his causes, thus coming to define the real meaning of the folk and protest movement that shaped the 1960s.

Get the tone

Any kind of acoustic will be suitable for this, from a small parlour style to a large dreadnought (Woody used both). The most important factors are a strong sounding bass end and clear-toned trebles so the chords and bass don't muddy up – in essence, a good sonic balance. Woody is best known for playing a 1945 Gibson Southern Jumbo and a signature model is now available.



LISTENING SUGGESTIONS Woody's tracks were often recorded in a piecemeal fashion, so it's hard to give a chronology to his releases as these days they tend to wind up on compilations. With that in mind it's probably best to start with a Greatest Hits to get an overall flavour and then delve into some of the Smithsonian Folkways recordings to really get a sense of what he was about. This Land Is Your Land remains his most famous song.

EXAMPLE WOODY GUTHRIE STYLE

[Bar 1] To get this style down requires a relaxed picking hand and independence between thumb and picking or strumming fingers. In the main it's best to use the thumb to pick the bass notes (sixth, fifth and fourth strings) and a downward 'flick' of the first finger to facilitate the chord on the higher strings. Also, using just one finger allows you to keep going at the required pace. Paul McCartney developed his own version of this playing style.

[Bar 3] This is typical of Woody's approach; we're based around a simple G chord shape but within it he creates variety with hammered-on bass notes against strummed chords on the top strings – very Dylan or Donovan.

[Bar 9] The bass notes here on beat 3 (the C) and beat 4 (the G) are the classic folk self-accompaniment style; the root note of the chord, C, followed by the 5th, the G. Both are 'framed' by the chord.

The score is written in G major (one sharp) and 4/4 time. It consists of 12 measures, grouped into four systems of three measures each. Each system includes a treble clef staff with chords and a bass staff with fingerings. The chords are labeled G7, G6, G7, G6, G13, G, C7, G, and D7. The bass staff shows a mix of strummed chords and single-note bass lines with fingerings (0, 2, 3, 1, 2). Measure numbers 1, 4, 7, 10, and 13 are indicated at the start of their respective systems.

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EXAMPLE WOODY GUTHRIE STYLE

[Bar 15] When playing in this style it's good to become proficient with bass runs – here the bass runs down from the D7 chord to hit the root of the G chord at the start of the next bar.

[Bar 17] We have a slightly different, more 'riff' based idea here, which gives some breathing space away from the more busy chord strumming section. The emphasis here should be on getting those hammer-ons clean and crisp.

[Bar 23] Again we see the use of the bassline to connect the chords, this time from C major down to A minor.

[Bar 31] And, finally, a long bass run to finish things off. The key thing here is to know your major scales in all the crucial keys in the open position – having this knowledge allows you to easily create these ascending or descending bass runs with which to connect any chords in a progression.

The musical score is written for guitar in G major (one sharp). It consists of five systems of music, each with a treble and bass staff. The bass staff includes detailed fingering and bar numbers.

- System 1 (Bars 16-18):** Treble staff shows a G chord. Bass staff shows a descending bass line from D7 to G.
- System 2 (Bars 19-21):** Treble staff shows C, Csus2/B, Am, and D7 chords. Bass staff shows a descending bass line from C to A.
- System 3 (Bars 22-24):** Treble staff shows C, Csus2/B, Am, D7, and G chords. Bass staff shows a descending bass line from C to A.
- System 4 (Bars 26-28):** Treble staff shows C7 and G chords. Bass staff shows a descending bass line from C to A.
- System 5 (Bars 29-31):** Treble staff shows D7, G, and G5 chords. Bass staff shows a descending bass line from D7 to G.